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Nick Brignola

One of the great voices of the baritone saxophone, Nick Brignola was born in Troy, NY on July 17, 1936. He attended Ithaca and Berklee Colleges but was largely self taught and by the late '50s Nick had recorded with Herb Pomeroy and Cal Tjader. He had a lengthy association with trumpeter Ted Curson interspersed with short stints in the bands of Woody Herman and Sal Salvador. Nick experimented with fusion as a leader of his own group, but is known today as the leading exponent of hard bop baritone sax. He has recorded numerous albums on a number of labels including "Baritone Madness" where he is joined by fellow baritonist Pepper Adams. Nick can be heard at jazz festivals and parties and often offers up an unusual original sound on a rarely seen metal clarinet.

Nick was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, on July 28, 1997 at the college.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and it's my great pleasure to have saxophonist extraordinaire Nick Brignola. Welcome to Hamilton.

NB: Nick to be here, Monk.

MR: I pulled out my now-famous duct taped Leonard Feather book from about '68, and I wanted to read something, and wonder if you actually said this. It said your "ambition is to become one of the top five baritone sax players in jazz." And, well since you did that about twenty-five years ago, what's your more recent goal been?

NB: Oh, I don't know. My recent goal is to survive. I originally said that because I was in the process of figuring out whether I was going to be a baritone sax player or just be an alto player, which was my first saxophone. But through the efforts of Harry Carney, who always kept encouraging me to be a baritone player, I figured, well, between Harry Carney and all these other guys like Gerry Mulligan and all of that – that's like three or four -- so if I could just be one of the five guys. So it was that kind of thing. And I don't even think I said it to be, you know, printed in concrete — it was just an offhand conversation to somebody — I think it was Ira Gitler, or somebody.

MR: I was wondering how that, when he did that, did he have different people going out and —

NB: As I remember, yeah. I just spoke to Ira a couple of weeks ago and they were supposed to put the latest edition out a year ago November. You know Leonard Feather died. So things kind of slowed up. And Ira was left with the big responsibility, and as you know now it's kind of easy to put that kind of a book together back in the old days. Now we have millions of jazz players. Everybody in the world plays jazz, so we can't get everybody in the world in one book. So it takes a long time.

MR: It's like where do you draw the line between this one and the next.

NB: Right.

MR: I know the *Grove* —

NB: Is Kenny G going to get in there?

MR: That would be almost worth putting him in there just to read the press, you know, just to see the letters you'd get.

NB: But it's a monumental effort to put that book together and it's going to be a while probably before the next one comes out. But it's nice to be in the books.

MR: Yeah, you have a nice write-up in the *Grove*, actually, I don't know if you've seen it but it's very nice. Also in, there's a big compilation that just came out of many, many jazz CD's and you're in there with some nice reviews of your work.

NB: Ah. That I wasn't aware of.

MR. Alto first? That is from school?

NB: You want to go right from the beginning?

MR: Well, I know, it all started when you saw your first what —

NB: No, no, my first instrument was clarinet. I had a uncle that lived — my younger uncle who was about ten years older than I am, took clarinet lessons and he was very bad. But he used to leave his clarinet up on the mantelpiece and then he would go out and play. And I used to sit and watch him. So I would just take his clarinet and play it. So in other words I figured out how he fingered and what it was supposed to sound like, so I figured out all the notes, and that was it. So my grandfather happened to come in one day, his father, and he thought it was his son playing, and here it was this, you know, little kid fooling around with this thing, and right away he went to my father and said, "Get this guy a clarinet and get him some lessons." Well I proceeded to get a new metal Cavalier clarinet, and I took about maybe two or three months of clarinet lessons as I remember, and hated every bit of it because I didn't realize it at the time I was playing by ear, and the teacher that I had was an old Italian fellow that if you made mistakes he would hit you on the fingers with a ruler or something. Needless to say I was getting my fingers bashed in. But he would always make the mistake of playing something first, and then after I heard it I would repeat it. But he thought I was reading it. Well my comeuppance was the day he found out that I wasn't reading, and he had a fit, and it was like he turned me in to my father, you know it was like, "He's not really going to be able to do anything." So believe it or not, Monk, that was the end of any formal training I ever had.

MR: No kidding.

NB: So I am self taught.

MR: I have to say that that kind of story we've heard before, in that the teachers at that time first of all were very strict — Jerry Jerome said something about that, that the teacher hit

him and he went home and told his father and his father hit him. But the fact that you were playing by ear was not good enough.

NB: Right. And also the material that he was training me to play was not what I wanted to play. So I used to play with the radio. I would listen — most of the — well you may not have been around them, but most of the band leaders back then played clarinet. It was Benny Goodman, Artie Shaw, Jimmy Dorsey, Woody Herman. Clarinet was all over the place. So I used to just play along with the radio. And most of the pop music of the day was the big band music. So that's what I grew up on. I learned a million tunes — not really knowing that I was learning tunes. And then came the '50s. I heard Stan Kenton's band. And that band stuck out because the harmonies in that band had nothing to do with the harmonies I had heard before. Then I heard the Claude Thornhill band and all of a sudden my ears started to be intrigued by the more advanced harmony. And I started to play that way on the clarinet. And all of a sudden I was getting criticized, you know, "You're playing wrong notes." You know back then it was like forbidden territory. Then all of a sudden the saxophone came into vogue, my first biggest influence in my life on saxophone was Paul Desmond.

MR: Can I wind back just for a second?

NB: Sure.

MR: The grandfather you mentioned, was he the one that played with John Phillip Sousa?

NB: Yes. How that came about was he was not a — my grandfather was born in Italy and he was a musician first. And then when he got married and came to the United States he had to support a family so he became a tailor. And he played gigs on the side. And a few times he was called to play with the Sousa band. And Sousa wanted him to, you know, be part of the — he was a great tuba player. And my grandmother said no dice, you know, you'd better stay home and make a living. So he wound up actually still being a great musician staying home. He wound up playing tuba in marching bands and concert bands, which I used to go with him all the time. He always used to take me to hear these old, like Italian concert bands and parade bands. So he was kind of my idol. When I grew up I wanted to put on a uniform and march in a parade. And you know he was always encouraging me to play music.

MR: Now the tunes that you were hearing from the radio — jazz was really the popular music of the day —

NB: It was dance music, and World War II had a lot to do with some of the music that came out. There was a lot of sentimentality, you know, the soldier going off to war, the family waiting for them, the communication. Music was a very big communicator. It kept things together. I mean we have e-mail and computers and stuff like that today. So the music was kind of the bond between the soldier being away and the family home. And also, just

life in general was centered around music. Music had a lot to do with the '30s, '40s and early '50s.

MR: And that it was played more in the home, on the piano.

NB: Very little television so you put on records or you listened to the radio. And on the radio you could hear a lot of these band broadcasts. You know half the time you could hardly hear it, but it was enough to pique your interest and keep your interest in the music. But that was the case. You know it was just — the pop music of the day just happened to be that kind of music which happened to be one of the very great foundations of jazz music.

MR: You were a pretty young boy during the war years, right?

NB: I was born in '36 so that makes me like ten years old after the war was over.

MR: Do you have memories of —

NB: Oh, yeah.

MR: What kind of things were going on from a family sense?

NB: Well I remember one day, my father was a doctor — my father was a general practitioner and because there was a shortage of doctors, most of the younger doctors went off to war. He stayed behind and we had, I think our city of Troy at the time was 85,000, I'm taking a guess. But there were maybe like fifty or sixty doctors, and that was it, to service all of those people. So he was very busy. And I can remember we had air raids, assuming we were going to be bombed. So you'd have to shut all the lights off, so the whole city would be pitch black. But guys like myself were given little tiny lanterns with like three watt bulbs in them. And our job was to stand on the street corner with the lantern and assist people. And I thought that was great, like I was almost like a soldier you know. So they gave me this little lantern, and every time we'd hear the air raid sirens they'd turn the lights out, and I'd walk out and walk up to the corner and stand there with my light. And on the other corner there'd be another kid. And you know we were like, in the war, we were fighting the war too. In fact we were looking for the Germans on that street that night. But I have memories of that, you know I mean being involved and also some of the guys on my block got killed you know, they didn't come home, and the families, I could always remember the big sorrow that was generated by that. You know so-and-so just got killed in Germany. And the next thing you'd know there'd be a star in his mother's window.

MR: You probably had some German residents in Troy.

NB: Oh, sure. It was a melting pot. Where I lived it was South Troy which was mostly Italians, Polish people, Germans, a lot of Jewish people there, and I went to school with — I'd say 30 or 40 percent of my class was black. So I really lived in a melting pot area and got — and my father was a doctor to all of those people.

MR: Did the German residents take any kind of heat from your neighborhood?

NB: I remember hearing stories of the generation before me, all of them took heat. The Irish gave heat to the Italians — the Italians gave heat to — you know it was that kind of thing. It was a rivalry between the neighborhoods. But I think the war did something. It pulled everybody together. and everybody was together. You know some people refer to it as "the last great war." In other words, you couldn't write a Hollywood script any better than World War II. You know, we got attacked, and in a very short time were able to beat the rest of the world. We were the good guys.

MR: Your school experience in a multi-racial atmosphere, did it affect your attitudes at all in later life?

NB: What it did do was give me a well rounded idea of what was going on. And when I started to play jazz I had to deal with all of that. Better that then being in a sheltered situation, not really knowing what life was about. Not that I knew exactly what life was about, but I knew a lot of black people, I knew their humor, I knew their contributions to the culture, and the Polish people and the Italians. I mean I grew up with all that kind of music. Like when I used to go out and play weddings as a kid, we played Polish hops and we played Italian tarantellas, and we played blues, and we did all of that. So I was used to this kind of thing. So when I moved to New York and got involved with jazz music, I was home.

MR: What about, did you fit into the school band situation?

NB: Not at all. Actually I did fool my high school teacher. I was first clarinet in the concert band and in the marching band, and what else, is there — the orchestra. Couldn't read a note. Luckily the guy next to me was a great reader.

MR: You really had big ears.

NB: Yeah. I had a real good sound. In fact my grandfather always referred to it as "the voice." He always used to say in broken Italian, "you have a-the voice — the sound." Whatever that meant. In later years I guess I kinda got the message. Because if you hear me play clarinet, I do have some kind of a classical sound in a sense, and I never studied. I mean that was the sound I heard all the time. I discussed this with Buddy DeFranco at one time and he had the same kind of background really, and grew up as a little Italian kid playing the clarinet. But you hear all these Italian marches and all of these clarinet things, and that sound kind of, it's a classical sound but it's got a little bit more emotion in it I think. I don't know. Anyway, I got to the point where if we had received a new piece in school, on the side I'd get the fellow next to me, I'd say, I was looking at it and I'd say I didn't know what that was. I'd say, "Play that for me." And he'd play it and then I'd play it and then I'd memorize it and that would be it. So I used to sit there and look at the music but I might as well have been reading a Superman comic book. And I played for two years and

the conductor never knew. Maybe he did know, I don't know. Now that I'm older I think that guy knew but he wanted me in the band.

MR: He liked your sound so he — yeah.

NB: That was it. So and then just to continue that while we're there, I was told, don't be a professional musician, you know, go to school. Because when you fail as a professional musician you'll have something to fall back on. So I applied and somehow got into Ithaca College. I wasn't really able to read music well.

MR: As a music major?

NB: As a music major, and as a clarinet major. I never attended a — I'm at a loss for words as to the — where you get together in a group, like ensembles?

MR: Yeah, sure.

NB: I never attended ensembles. You know the great Walter Beeler?

MR: Yeah.

NB: Walter Beeler called me into the office one day. He said, "You've been here for six months and you haven't showed up to one ensemble. What is your problem?" And I said, "I can't read music." And he almost hit the ceiling. He said, "What do you mean you can't read music? How'd you get into this school?" I said, "I don't know." So I played for him and he laughed. It was like, "You can play but you can't read?" Anyway, that was it. Somehow I had a mental block against reading. I was afraid to do it. I was almost like scared to apply myself to do it. And everybody would say "what you can do you can't learn. Reading is a mechanical thing, it's easy, I'll show you how." And I'd sit down and I just never could get it. But eventually I got it by the exact same way I learned how to play — just by listening, looking and rhythmical figures and seeing them over and over again and I know how they went, and then sitting — when I was with Woody Herman's band when I first went with him I wasn't a great reader but I could read adequately. I would sit on the bus and sit there and subdivide and count. That's how I learned how to read. And I think as you know, reading is something you have to do, I think a lot. If you do it a lot you're good at it. It's like anything else. But I didn't want to be in a big band. Big bands never really interested me. I just wanted to play jazz. I just wanted to play what I heard.

MR: You went on to Berklee, right?

NB: I won the first scholarship offer there. I stayed there a year. Same thing — couldn't read but I was in all the ensembles. In fact Herb Pomeroy actually had another baritone player sit there and read the parts and I took all of the solos. But I would look over his shoulder and watch him read and that helped me to learn how to read too.

MR: When did you first get on the baritone?

NB: Actually in 1956 maybe? My alto was — this is on the back of one of my albums, I can't remember which one. But my alto needed some repair and as usual I'd take it to the music store. And they always let me take an alto. They had no altos but they had a baritone. So I said "I don't want to play that." "Oh gee, you're only going to play it tonight, take it. It's just like an alto only it's bigger. You've just got to blow harder." That's what he told me. So I took it on the gig and I didn't like it at all. Everybody else liked it though. The rest of the band said, "Oh man, you should play it." "Not me, I don't want to play this." And I don't know, I kind of filed that, what it felt like to play it in the back of my mind. Then about six months later I had a chance to buy a baritone real cheap, so I bought it. And one thing led to another. I would play alto but every once in a while I'd pick up the baritone. And I noticed that every time I picked up the baritone I got more reaction from people — critics too. Like I was on the *Down Beat* poll when I was 20 years old, because of the baritone, not because of the alto. So I realized that this might be a ticket, to get in the door. But I didn't like the horn, I just didn't like it. I heard and felt alto. And then I was at the Cafe Bohemia playing there because we were voted the best college jazz group in the United States at Ithaca that year, and part of the prize was to play the Randall's Island Jazz Festival, and appear for a week at the Cafe Bohemia. So we were opposite in fact Ronnie Zito, a great drummer from this area was in that band. We appeared opposite Buddy Rich for a week. And critics and people started to come in and listen to their school boys play jazz. And I was getting all the press. And one night I looked up and Gerry Mulligan was sitting right in front of me, smiling, and I looked at him and I kinda knew who he was. I wasn't a big fan of his style of playing the baritone, but I mean I respected him for who he was. When I got off the bandstand he wanted to look at my mouthpiece. He liked the mouthpiece I had, which was an old Brillhart, I still have it. And he played my horn and he said, "Do you want to sell this mouthpiece?" And I just — that was the only mouthpiece I ever had so I said, "Gee, no, it's all I have." He says, "Well come on, I want you to meet somebody." He took me to the bar and he introduced me to Harry Carney. And at that point, in fact there's a book out called *The World of Duke Ellington* by Stanley Dance. And in the Harry Carney section he mentions the night he met me at the Cafe Bohemia with Gerry Mulligan. But anyway, I'd met him that night and right until he died we were very good friends. I mean I used to go see that band every chance I could get to see them, and he always encouraged me, "You should play the baritone — you're a baritone player, play the baritone." So I don't know, one thing led to another and it was a love/hate relationship. In fact it still is sometimes. I'd rather play alto many other nights.

MR: It's pretty heavy too.

NB: Yeah, the older I get it gets a little heavier. Finally get somebody to make a fiberglass one, you know, that comes apart and fits in a box about this big. But anyway it's been that kind of a thing. But I got to the point where okay, if I'm going to play this thing then I'm going to really play it. And I always attacked it that way. And I always say "attacked" because it's a big fight. Every time I pick it up it's a fight. Whereas the alto — I think I'm just an alto player really. I hear the alto better, I feel—

MR: Well your fluency on it sounds like you're thinking alto almost.

NB: And I always play the high end if you will notice. That's another reason I tried to extend the range of the baritone to give me more high end. Also no other horn has the range that horn has if you do extend the high range. So I feel I've contributed something to the advancement of the horn but more than that it's just I really enjoy playing it. And when I'm in my top shape I fear no one. But I'd still rather be an alto player.

MR: I think the die's been cast, actually.

NB: Love/hate relationship. That's it.

MR: Well there was a lot of different kinds of music happening in the 50s. Did you get into, either by economic necessity or whatever, get into—

NB: I got into all of it, believe me. You're from around here, right?

MR: Yeah.

NB: Okay. Are you familiar with Sylvan Beach?

MR: Sure.

NB: Okay. I played there when I was a kid with a rhythm & blues band. In fact in re-hashing those years with people that know me and musicians from around here, I realize that we were all kind of doing the same thing but didn't know each other. Because I came from Albany basically. But I played rhythm & blues, I played — I actually swung from a trapeze upside-down playing alto.

MR: Get out.

NB: Oh, yeah. We were on the road and there was a group that used to appear on *The Ed Sullivan Show*, they were Las Vegas's biggest act, they were called "The Goofers." And they played rhythm & blues and they did comedy and everything. But one of the gimmicks was the sax player would swing on a trapeze. So we were playing in St. Louis and the guy had left his trapeze. So I got on it so I was fooling around and the guy says, "You think you can do that tonight?" And I said, "I'll try." Well that lasted about a week, because I got dizzy a few times and almost killed myself so I never got on the trapeze again. But there was another guy that came from this area — Jimmy Cavallo and the House Rockers. And Jimmy showed me how to "walk the bar." You know, so I did all of that. But Rhythm & Blues enabled me to learn how to — it put me in a situation where I could improvise and just blow anything I want. In other words I'd be up there kind of

thinking and hearing Paul Desmond, but I'd be honking, and I'd be playing all those harmonic things I heard the Claude Thornhill band play when we're playing like some current rock tune from the day. Like "Rock Around the Clock" by Bill Haiey is nothing but a blues, right? So once we played the head and started to blow, I just blew. I was Sonny Rollins at that point you know. But I learned how to play that way and then I used to go and sit in at jam sessions and in strange towns and learn tunes and sit in with people and that's kind of how I learned to play. That was school for me.

MR: I guess it's unfortunate that that kind of scene is not so prevalent today.

NB: Yeah I always say that I would hate to be a young musician growing up today because there's good and bad to it, you know like positive and negative to all angles. But most of the musicians I hear today are cookie cutter kind of people. Nothing wrong in that in a sense, I mean there are some great musicians. And I hear technical ability and I hear all kinds of great things, but I don't hear individuality as much as I used to hear it. And the individuality came about as everybody at that point learned how to play on their own, so you had all these little different flowers blooming. Now all the flowers kind of look alike and sound alike, and they're great, but it's a whole other thing.

MR: Did you get to a point, as you are playing mostly by ear, later on did you start to learn some theory and then say "oh that's what I was doing. I'm already doing it."

NB: Oh yeah. In fact I was on a panel one time and some guy said, "Oh" he said, "what you did was you wrote the book first and then you learned how to spell pronounce and create sentences." And I kind of thought about that and I said gee I guess so. Because I didn't know what I was doing. All I knew was it sounded right. And I didn't know why, but it was right. And I would argue all night long that it was right but I had no way of proving it. So that kind of said, you better learn what you're doing. So I, you know the ego is a great big thing. It's like I didn't want to let anybody know that I didn't know what I was doing, so I would coyly ask questions, instead of coming right out and saying, "Hey, what is a D minor seventh," I would say to a pianist, "Show me how you voice a D minor— how do you voice different ways on D minor seventh on a piano?" So I'd see the guy play, and then I would memorize those hands positions. And then I'd sit home and figure out what a D minor seventh was. And meanwhile this guy thought that I was just asking a general question, when I really didn't know anything. Then I found out that there was only twelve keys and if you bring it up a half step it's a E flat minor seventh, and the picture came to me and that's basically how I learned. But to be honest with you, when I'm up there playing now I'm very seldom — I'm still that kid playing by ear. I don't think of anything when I'm playing.

MR: No kidding.

NB: And I've had people ask me that. I mean occasionally I do think, I mean some tunes have different forms and some tunes demand a little bit more attention, you know, when you're playing them, so you won't get lost, and they have certain idiosyncrasies. So I think at those points. But when I'm just playing a tune that I've played for years, or something that is a familiar form, I'm free as a bird at that point.

MR: Well I would love to see some of the — occasionally in some of the jazz magazines, especially the educational ones — you'll see someone transcribe a solo and analyze it. And they'll often say, "Notice how the player has taken this particular scale and did this tertiary turnaround" and blah blah blah. And I'm thinking to myself maybe — but maybe not.

NB: Well that's happened to me. I've had people transcribe my — in fact my solos, a lot of my solos have appeared in some of those magazines. And what's funny is they'll send me the solo and I look at it. First of all it's very difficult for me to read. Second, they're asking me if it's right. And I say like, in other words, I've got to go listen to my record now and figure out if all these notes are night. So I always used to say, "Yeah it's right." I'd just send it back in and say, "Yeah, it's right." Because you know I wasn't thinking of — it wasn't that way. I just played it. And if you want to write it down and transcribe it and study it that's fine. But I mean it's not like *The Bible* you know. It's one chorus in a lifetime. And there's many more choruses that have come after that, and many more hopefully will come. So I mean, but as a learning device I realize the value of transcribing. But I think too much emphasis is on that sometimes. And also this pseudo-intellectual application to it sometimes, like you were saying, it's like this third bar is pure genius, when it just happened. I mean if it is, that's great.

MR: Maybe that's the genius of it — that it just happened.

NB: Yeah. So in other words like if you study this and you apply this you will be a genius too. That's what I don't like about it. But I think there's a little bit too much emphasis on the educational aspect of it. Not that there shouldn't be education, but it's not the end all. And that's why I think a lot of the players to me are boring to listen to. I mean I hear some great players and I hear some great talented people that had they been in my generation would probably really have blossomed. But in this context in this generation, are not gonna. Because conditions and the environment and just other situations that do exist are not conducive for that person to advance to their potential.

MR: That's really interesting. I want to go back to, you mentioned Paul Desmond, which surprises me a little bit.

NB: Oh it surprises a million people. It even surprises me sometimes, but I'm constantly hearing that guy. I got to know him in his later years. I met him a few times when I was a kid but the thing that appealed to me was his simplicity. And I certainly don't play simple

all the time. But there's a certain lyrical simplicity that he has that makes me play a certain way. And not that he was the only guy — I mean, you know Miles certainly influenced me too. But Paul is a saxophone player, being the first — they say you never forget your first love, you know? Like a woman or whatever. It's like I don't forget my first influence. And he just played some great things. His earlier records really knocked me out. In fact, my favorite album, just for the record, is "Dave Brubeck at Oberlin." And I mentioned it to Paul one time. It's the best he ever played. He didn't — it was downhill from there. I mean I always enjoyed his playing, but that was the album I lived with, and if you listen to it he played with such excitement and such energy. And I mentioned it to him one time and he just looked at me and smiled. It was like, "Yeah I kind of remember that night." If you listen to the record, the whole group is popping, which it didn't always do. But he was a very big influence. And, just a kid, you know, first idol. Out here is this little, short, Italian, stocky kid that wanted to look like a six foot tall guy with horn rimmed glasses. I used to try to stand like him, you know, and even tried to get a mouthpiece like he had one time until I found out that Gregory mouthpieces were very hard to find. But that kind of hero worship. But then as I grew up I got out of that but I still appreciate the lyricism that that guy had. I mean he was just great.

MR: Yeah, there was a certain sound to that group. I had an experience of just hearing "Take Five" one day on the car radio, and I said, "Man that's it. What is that?" That kind of starts a whole process maybe of going from one thing to the next.

NB: Right. Exactly. And you know of course then I got turned on to Charlie Parker and the usual. I kept going forward and backwards, forward — every time I ran out of inspiration I would go back. And then I'd run out of that and I'd jump forward and listen to some new guys, and back and forth, back and forth. But every once in a while, there's old Paul sitting there. I just recently recorded an album with a 51 piece orchestra, the Metropole Orchestra in Holland. And I did a version of "East of the Sun." And in the midst of all this, I don't know if you've ever played with an orchestra, you probably have, but there's a feeling that you just can't duplicate when you're right in the middle of all of this — strings and harps, and all of a sudden this big sound hits you. And you're just free as a bird and you're flying over this you know. And I started to play and all of a sudden this quote that Desmond played came out of me. And it's a very hip quote. I don't want to get too technical, but he starts on the tritone substitution of the melody and he just plays. So I played what he played — I hinted at what he played, but then I took it somewhere else. But he was there with me that day.

MR: That's great — all those years later.

NB: Many years later it still influenced me.

MR: I'm going to pause for a second — can we open the windows? I think we should it's pretty hot in here.

[pause]

MR: Let's see. Cal Tjader. You moved out the west coast?

NB: No I was visiting the west coast. My parents decided to take a cross country drive, and last minute I decided to go with them. And I had heard about this music called "west coast jazz" so I wanted to check that out. So we arrived in San Francisco, my aunt and uncle lived there and we were staying with them, and I read about this place called the Black Hawk, which is where Brubeck got his start and Cal Tjader happened to be playing there. And I didn't know who Cal Tjader was, but I went down there and took my horn. And it was a jam session on a Sunday as I remember it. And I walked in and walked right up to Cal and said, "I'd like to sit in." He said, "Where you from?" and I told him. At the time he had Vince Guaraldi on piano, Al McKibbon on bass, Willie Bobo on regular drums, and Mongo Santamaria on conga drums.

MR: And which horn did you have?

NB: Baritone. So I sat in and I wound up, he hired me. There was a Cuban tenor player playing with him. And he was leaving to go back to New York. And Cal kind of all of a sudden liked the baritone sound, you know with the baritone and the vibes is a little bit different. So I played, oh I don't know, I think I played five or six of those jam session things that they did. Because on the weekends he had his regular quintet and had their own thing without the saxophone player. But I got to play and all of a sudden people were coming around in San Francisco like the writers and the people from the San Francisco papers and all of a sudden I started to get like a little reputation but I came back to New York with my family, and then I said well I'm going to move out here. So the following year I did move out there, and I stayed about six months, and I worked. That's when I, you know that album "Cannonball at the Jazz Workshop?" I was there. We used to play the Workshop. And I first got to play with Wes Montgomery. Because there was another group out there called The Master Sounds. Buddy Montgomery, Monk's brother, and Wes' brother, and Monk Montgomery played bass. Anyway they had a group and they kept talking about their brother Wes Montgomery from home who played great guitar and he was coming out to visit them. And he did. He came out and they put him with an organ trio — it was an organ, drums and guitar. So I went in and I was in the men's room and Wes Montgomery came in and I knew who he was, so I said to him, "I know your brothers and I just got through playing with them." And he said, "Well get your horn and come on up." So I wound up playing with Wes. And then about a year later he was big time in New York. He was recording and he was Wes Montgomery. But they were great times out there. But the problem was there wasn't enough work and enough —

what's the word — inspiration or creative juices were not happening for me out there. I had to come back to New York so I did.

MR: In New York what was 52nd Street like when you were there?

NB: It was very easy — it had access, you could go in and out of all the clubs. Like I used to pay a dollar and a half and go in and sit in the peanut gallery in Birdland. You didn't have to buy a drink. The peanut gallery was an area to the left of the bandstand where if you didn't want to drink, you just wanted to hear the music, you paid your dollar and a half and sat there. It was the greatest seat in the house because you were right on top of the bandstand. So I used to try to get the end seat or the end block of seats, because that always put me like I would be this far away from Thelonious Monk's fingers and, you know, all the great piano players. And you'd be right on the bandstand. And like Sonny Rollins when he made that couple of trio albums there, I mean you were sitting right there for a dollar and a half. But it was easy to park and you know, like I said before the interview here when we were taking about how it was, it was very accessible. I remember — remember Joe Farrell, the tenor player?

MR: Sure.

NB: Joe Farrell and I used to play club dates and then it'd be like twelve, one o'clock in the morning and we'd get on the subway and go up to Harlem and sit in up there. And we were accepted, you know, I mean we weren't — if we were jazz musicians you were in. Nobody bothered us and I mean you felt completely safe, within reason, I mean there's always some —

MR: Well I'm glad you brought that up because I've been curious about the racial interaction in jazz and if it's changed over the years.

NB: I think there was always some kind of a racial problem. I mean obviously from the black end there was definitely a big problem. From the white end of it, we used to refer to it as "Crow Jim" you know, reverse racism. Whereas if you were white you really didn't have a right to play this music. And some white musicians actually gave up music, I mean actually believe that. And my belief is, you know it sounds cliché, but I mean it doesn't matter what color you are, if you can play you can play. So I used to say, "Okay, we can't play? I can't play? Come on up on the bandstand — let's see who can play and let's see who can't play." You know you can talk all night long but put your money where your mouth is. And that usually settled most of the problems. But on the other hand, it still does exist today, on both ends, and I think it's a problem we're going to have for eternity. I mean we've got to learn to live with it. And the other thing is we can't take it as seriously as most people — you know it's like if somebody says this little thing, it's politically incorrect, and I mean it's to the point now where it's ridiculous. And I think that's half the problem. Let's not take it — let's try to relax and just try to get along, and

the next thing you know it will happen, you know? If you listen to some of the white musicians from the '50s they say that, you know, they got along fine with everybody. Well maybe from their end it looked that way, but maybe it wasn't. Who knows? I wasn't really on the scene at that level then so I can't really comment on it but I've heard it from both ends. And everybody said everything was cool. But I don't know, I wonder.

MR: What about today? You know when you go to the jazz parties for instance, almost a hundred percent of the audience is white. The only time I noticed it different was on a jazz cruise, where it was much more mixed. But it seems like the majority of the musicians are white too.

NB: At the jazz parties?

MR: Yeah.

NB: I've played a number of them. There may be a few favorites, you know that are white, but I don't know I played like the Dick Gibson Jazz Party, which was the daddy of them all. He always had, I mean there'd be a lot of blacks there. I mean that's how I met most of them. I mean I got to meet people I would never have met had I not gone to these jazz parties. People like Marshall Royal, and I mean hanging with these guys and talking with them. Just to give you a quick thing there, I was looking for the altissimo fingerings on the clarinet, trying to get up in the high register, and I talked to Buddy DeFranco, Dick Johnson, Peanuts Hucko, Kenny Davern, Bob Wilbur — these are all great clarinet players, right? You know who showed me the best fingerings?

MR: Marshall Royal?

NB: Marshall Royal. And then Marshall says — I said to him, "You're only a dumb saxophone player, and you showed me those clarinet fingers." He started to laugh, he says, "Yeah, but people don't know that I was a clarinet player — I was a clarinet major." That was his axe. His fingerings, to this day, work for me. All the other fingerings are like, "Try this, maybe this will work, try that." Marshall was right on the money. But I mean I got to hang with Lockjaw Davis — when would I have been able to — So these parties were really a great thing. But for the most part a lot of it is a comprised of very tired music. I won't say great music or good music, but it's been overdone and you hear the same tunes and after a while, I see the same people in the audiences sometimes at different parties. They make a living of going around being in the audience at these jazz parties and they must — don't they get tired of hearing the same old tunes?

MR: I think it's kind of social show.

NB: It's a happening.

MR: You know if a musician today wanted to get into that circuit, what do they have to — besides that they have to play good — but is there other things? I mean like there's a standard repertory that you have.

NB: You just better know a lot of tunes from the '20s right up to the '50s, and you better be able to put your ego at the door and be able to fit in. I always looked at it as being a great character actor. You know if you're an actor on a stage, you can't go in there being the big star. But if you're a great character actor and somebody says, "Okay, at two o'clock you're going to be in this band," like Jay McShann's playing piano, Ray Brown's playing drums, Phil Woods playing alto, and Bob Wilber's playing clarinet. You know all of a sudden you're saying, "Wait a minute. What are we going to play?" Well we'll tell you that when you get there, but you better be ready to play this role. And I think the more you can do that, the more success you have. I used to see musicians come in like they're going to do their thing. And they weren't back there the next time. So I mean there's a point to where you've got to be one of the crowd. And it's fun. I won't mention any names, but a musician, when I first did one of these parties I was very disappointed because I was kind of with that head, "I'm going to go in and play what I do best, and I'm going to try to be as good as I can." And then I realized that they were just cutting my legs off. They were putting me in positions and putting me with musicians that wouldn't allow me to do what I — so I was kind of depressed and I was sitting there, and this guy, a famous alto player, said to me, "Cheer up," he says, "where else could you be with all these great musicians. It's a holiday." He says, "Look at it this way: it's nice to have a gig once a year that has nothing to do with music" which I thought was a great line. And you might — I'll tell you later who said that, but you probably know already.

MR: Well — yeah.

NB: But after I heard that it put everything in perspective and I laughed, and I was able to laugh at that point, and I said you know, he's right. Not that you shouldn't get up and play as good as you can, but don't take it so seriously, and just enjoy the situation.

MR: Well there's an art to that too — playing within the correct context.

NB: Exactly. Well I've always considered myself that kind of musician. Eclectic is the word? That's it. I had one of the first electric fusion bands back in the late '60s.

MR: I was going to ask about that.

NB: I think I was one of the first guys to run an alto sax through a wa-wa pedal. And I had guys like Dave Holland in my band, and you know guys that just left Miles. I remember one time coming home and listening on the radio, and I was with a bass player, and I said, "Geez that sounds like us." And it was Weather Report. This was back in the late '60s. So I was into that. I played with Dewey Redman and I played some avante garde music. These are experiences that to me I draw upon every time I get up to play. Because every situation is different. I get with a pianist that plays more traditional. I kind of start going in that groove, and kind of hold the fort there, and if I feel I can't expand that I'm able to jump into another direction because of the experience I've had. And all of a

sudden if there's a piano player who's harmonically a little bit more advanced, okay, I can go here with this guy, you know. All of a sudden I know what I can do and what I can't do. So each time is a very individual kind of situation and if you have all of these other experiences to draw from, you never run out of gas. I played with Vic Dickinson and Doc Cheatham, I played, you know Dixieland with these guys, I worked gigs with them. I mean they had their own thing going, their own humor, their own way of doing things, and I worked within that context. So when I come to these jazz parties, some of these same guys, Doc Cheatham, I worked with him twenty years ago, all of a sudden I'm on the bandstand again with him, so it was like old home week. At the same time you sit down and do a duo thing with Roger Kellaway and you need a radar machine to find the harmony sometimes, and we're doing it at a jazz party. It's just like — but it works. Because we happen to be playing the theme of a familiar tune, and we departed from it, took it where we wanted and came back, and they always remember the ending, and if you come back with the melody they're cool. Meanwhile they've allowed us to take this space trip. But I think that's how I've been able to survive, is being that character actor, musically. Being able to fit in any musical situation. And I take gigs sometimes that other jazz musicians probably wouldn't take, but I always find, to me it's just another experience and I'm going to do the best I can. I remember one time when I had that fusion band, it was on a Saturday, I played a church service, I played alto flute that morning in a church service. And then from twelve to four I played in a society orchestra, with the tux on, playing all the —you know. And then that evening I was the opening act for Miles Davis. So I said, yeah, that's a pretty good day. To be able to play those three gigs. And I'm saying, you know, who else could do that?

MR: That's something to pay attention to. That really is.

NB: Yeah. And I took pride in that. But I just, those are the kind of experiences I've had, and no gig was too bad for me to take sometimes, you know I always could get something out of it.

MR: And that's something you don't learn in school. I mean I'm not sure you can teach that kind of thing, but you learn to deal with it.

NB: No not really. Like if somebody called me for a wedding and I hadn't played flute for a while, I'd take the flute to the wedding, I'd practice it. It was a chance to play flute for three hours, get paid for it, get my chops up, so you can always make a positive thing out of a negative situation. Instead of saying, "No I'm not going to take that gig, I'm an artist, I don't play weddings." Not that I play that many weddings anymore, I've been lucky enough to be able to just play jazz really the last few years. But the character actor idea I think has enabled me to survive.

MR: I like that analogy. I may have to use that myself.

NB: Feel free.

MR: Thanks.

NB: I use it all the time.

MR: What's it like with the small record labels? Distribution and all that kind of stuff.

NB: Distribution is tough. You know you're competing with the big boys. Like I just came back from Europe. I was over there for five weeks total. I mean you see, I won't mention names, but you see certain musicians doing a Hewlett Packard ad, you know, they're getting money from computer — the big record companies put all their money behind something. They'll invent somebody, an image, put all their money behind them, and just force them down your throats to the point where they become famous and make a lot of money. Some of them last because they happen to be good players, and some of them aren't so good and they don't last, but that's the nature of the game. A small label is good in this respect: it allows you to record what you want to record. They're more interested in the music. I mean they all want to make money, at least break even, but their nut isn't so high and they allow you to do your own music, and to be honest with you, my distribution is getting better with Reservoir Records. I mean I go around now, I just came back from Italy, Holland and Finland, and the records were there. I mean there's not maybe seven hundred of them in the bin you know, but they're there. And it's the kind of thing I think it's available and if the people know about you they're going to be able to get the records, maybe with a little more effort than just walking into a music store. They might have to find the address of the record label and what have you, but the good thing is you're kind of allowed to do the music, whereas sometimes when you are a prisoner to these major labels, the short end of the stick is they control your music. And if you control an artist's music I think you've just taken the life out of the person. I mean unless then want to be controlled and their only interest is to be famous and make money. I got in this to play music, and I'm still in there to do it. And I'm too old now to change, you know, as far as I'm not going to sell out now. It'd be crazy for me. On the other hand, you never know.

MR: You never know what kind of offer might be around the corner.

NB: You never know.

MR: Are you able to pick the folks you want to work with on most of your records?

NB: For the most part, yeah. Sometimes, sometimes not, sometimes politically you have to do certain things, but for the most part I've been lucky, I've been able to have who I wanted. And even some of the ones that I didn't think were going to work out, turned out great. Sometimes you just feel that you may not have a certain rapport with a certain musician, but all of a sudden that musician brings something different, and it happens. So that has happened.

MR: I didn't ask you about — you had a year with Woody Herman?

NB: No, hell no. How about like three and a half months or something like that. There's two Brignolas. There's Mike Brignola, who is with Woody Herman's band now, happens to be the baritone player too. He has the record for being probably next to Frank Tiberi, the guy the most, the fellow that's been with Woody Herman's band the longest. He joined in 1979 and has been the baritone player since then. Coincidentally, we have the same name, and we play the same instrument. He's about twenty years younger than I am. His name is Mike. And we think we might be related because his ancestry kind of is from the same area of Italy as mine. Anyway, to make a long story short, I wasn't with Woody's band too — I told you before, I didn't like big bands, I didn't feel comfortable in big bands. And most big bands didn't feature the baritone player too much, you know the tenor, especially Woody's band, was mostly tenor. But I got to play a lot actually, due to the efforts of Sal Nistico, who got me on the band. Sal used to say to Woody, you know, "Let him play." And Woody would say, "Well we don't have any chart for him." "Well let him play on one of my tunes," you know, Sal was gracious in that respect. And I got to play, you know. And as I remember when I did leave the band, Woody said to me, "Man, we're just starting to write some charts for you, why are you leaving?" But it was at a time in my life when I just had to get out, I just couldn't' do it.

MR: Was it constant road work?

NB: Yeah, most of it was, but it was also like there's an album called "Woody Herman 1964" on the Phillips label. If you look on the back there, it was recorded the day Kennedy got killed, November 22, we were in the studio recording that day. And I had just — my second daughter was born, and I was kind of —you know, the President gets killed, my daughter was born with a liver problem, I'm on the road, I didn't really like it, so I just said who needs it, so I left. And those other two incidents helped me make my decision. But it was a musical decision too. But what was funny is Woody asked me to come back, I mean throughout the years Woody would say, "Any time you want to come back" you know. And one time they were going to Japan and I was tempted because I had never been to Japan and I was going to go. And then something happened where I was going to do something with my own group, that fusion group I had. And I just felt well gee, you know, realistically I've got to do my own thing and let's go with this. And in retrospect I should have gone with Woody. But it would have been nice. But I always saw Woody, right up until he died, you know the year he died I saw him all the time, we hung out and laughed and reminisced and whatever.

MR: He had quite a character on baritone for a while, was it Serge?

NB: Oh, yeah, I heard all the Serge stories.

MR: Chaloff is it?

NB: Serge Chaloff, yeah. People used to say "you must have listened to Serge—" I never listened to Serge Chaloff. I mean Serge died when I first started to play. And he didn't record a lot of records. I heard about him, and the few times I heard him, he didn't knock me out. I wasn't too interested. I was like, well yeah he plays good, but I don't know, it doesn't knock me. out. But lately I've listened to him. I've listened to some records that were re-released and maybe I think there were records that maybe were never released, some recordings. And he was a hell of a player. So maybe he'll influence me now or something, I don't know.

MR: Well you've been able to get together with some of your contemporaries on the baritone on some of your records, right?

NB: Oh, yeah. I recorded a duo, the first time I ever did it was with Pepper Adams and then we did one with three baritones, Cecil Payne and Ronnie Cuber. And I just did one three months ago with three baritones — Ronnie Cuber, Gary Smulyan and myself, and we did the music of Gerry Mulligan. And we took all Mulligan tunes. And maybe Gerry would roll over in his grave if he heard us playing it, but it was some interesting things. You know, with three different guys playing Mulligan's music, of all the musics. But one baritone is bad enough, we don't need three. It was a fun experience, let's put it that way. I always enjoyed, it's like having — one time I remember we had, Harry Carney died and we had twenty-four baritones and a rhythm section at St. Peter's Cathedral. Most of the people there just owned the horns, maybe about six of us could play. But just to see that many baritones.

MR: What a choir.

NB: Like wow. But it was like a sound I don't really cherish.

MR: You know there's been, I guess we can consider you an Upstate New York guy, all the way from Albany to Buffalo, and there's been really quite a long list of great jazz players to come out of —

NB: Usually like from the center of the state, you know, J.R. Monterose, Sal Nistico, the Mangione brothers and then on the west side we had like Don Menza and Sam Noto. But I think I'm the only one from Albany.

MR: You know I just noticed a weird thing as you went through those names is they all end in a vowel.

NB: Yeah, they all happen to be Italian.

MR: What is it about that?

NB: I don't know. They often used to say that, you know like all these Italian saxophone players. I don't know. I think it's just coincidence. On the other hand, I don't know.

MR: Hot-blooded I guess.

NB: I don't know. They talk about the Texas Tenors, you know, and a certain sound indicative of certain areas. I never really heard those guys until I'd already been playing. I mean I knew Chuck Mangione and Sal, and I knew J.R. But I didn't meet Sammy Noto until I'd been playing maybe ten, fifteen years, and I don't ever remember meeting Don Menza — and I'm sure I'm leaving out some guys, I'm sure there's some other great players around. But we never really hung together. I mean I was from Albany and I just, I never saw these guys. Once in a while they would come to Albany, like J.R., when I first met J.R. he came to Albany to play a gig and I found out he was from Utica, but I didn't hang out with him that much. You know in later years we hung out, but as far as influencing each other, I don't know. But there was a certain flair I guess that always people said that the Italian tenor players from Upstate New York. So I'll go along with perpetuating that myth.

MR: Yeah, why not? We'll start it up anew. Was there competition, and is there still a lot of competition to get what work is out there?

NB: Oh yeah, sure. I mean there's only so much out there and now you've got all these music schools releasing these kids that are great musicians you know, in many respects more well prepared for certain gigs then I'll ever be prepared for. But when I used to go do clinics I used to make mention of the fact, I'd say, "Listen, after you leave school here and you're all prepared and you're ready to go do your thing, just remember that guys like me, and there's a whole mess of us out there waiting for you guys. And just remember, we're all after the same gig. So you'd better be ready." And when I first started to say that I was trying to tell them that it's not going to be easy, that once you get out there you're competing with everybody and anything. In school now you're only competing with little Johnny or little Ethel on the alto for the first chair in the band and all that, that's a simple situation. When you get out in the world, now it's like everything's up for grabs, and are you ready for that. That was my message. But then it got to the point where it was like I got thinking, I said wait a minute there are so many gigs, I'm going to kill this kid when he comes out. You know, I'm not going to let him get that job, you know. And then I would tell them that. I'd say, "When you come out, it's like a boxing match. I'm going to knock your brains out so you'd better be ready to beat me up, you know, because I'm going to take your job." And they would sit there and shake and the music teacher would come up to me later and say, "Hey, what'd you tell them that for?" And then some of them would say, "Boy I'm glad you told them that." Because really that's what it's about.

MR: Sure and they've been doing that for years, I mean the Kansas City tenor battles and all of that.

NB: That's the way the music was brought up. There is a competition, yeah. But it's also a respect too. There's a competition but when you know you're in the room with the same kind of maybe not the exact — how can you equate talent — but I mean when you're among company that you know at least as your equal or maybe better than you or a little bit less than you, there's a respect there that, I mean that's the way I feel, I don't know how other people feel. But I always have that respect for people. And yeah, I'm going to knock your brains out, but when the game's over, we're going to sit around and hang and tell stories and have a good time. Sometimes it's not like that. It's a very vicious, personal thing, and I think that's when it gets lost somewhere.

MR: Well we should wrap up, I know you have to go play some jazz.

NB: Yeah. We just got started. This should be a ten hour interview.

MR: Yeah this is great. Well we'll do Part Two actually, you know when you come back. We think about, you're on your way to the gig, and how much preparation in your mind are you doing? Is there any?

NB: It's mental. It's all mental to me. Like five or ten minutes before the gig I start thinking about tunes. There's a feel that you get when you walk into the club, there's a feeling of first of all, the audience helps. I mean if there's an audience there you feel, mmm, okay, I've got to play tonight. Not that you don't have to play if there's no audience, but you just feel an obligation — there's people there spending money, okay, you've got to bring it up to this notch, you know, immediately. But I start thinking of tunes, and just different things to do to make this night a little bit more unique than last night. And I've always been a gamer in the sense that if I was a football player, I wouldn't want to go to practice, I'd be late. But when it came time to play the game I'll kill ya. I'm ready to play. So that's the way I am musically. I don't do any preparation as far as, you know, like I wasn't practicing all afternoon for tonight's gig. But I'm ready to play. And that's the way I like it. I like to have that little bit of edge. It also depends on who you're working for. You have to figure the capabilities and limitations of the people that you're going to play with, and what kind of material you might have to play. Sometimes I'm sure maybe you've been on gigs where the piano player brings a fake book, doesn't know half the tunes, and all of a sudden ninety percent of the repertoire that you'd like to do is by the board so you've got to go in another direction. So I think you have to be prepared for that. I just like to play. And I'm the kind of guy, you wake me up at 3:30 in the morning, hand me the horn and say "here's a half a cup of coffee, let's blow," and I'd say okay. Whereas somebody else might tell you to get lost. I just really enjoy playing, and I think that's what really keeps me going.

MR: Well you've got the Montalbano family on tonight and you should be able to play pretty much what you want.

NB: Yeah I really enjoy playing with both of them, they're both very talented and young Ricky I think is going to really, if he keeps his head on straight, he's going to make a mark. He already has as far as I'm concerned, or I wouldn't be using him.

MR: Right. Well great. On behalf of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive I'd like to thank Nick Brignola for joining us.

NB: Thank you for having me.

MR: Perhaps we will do Part Two.

NB: Let's do Part Two, yeah, I'm ready. I'll come back with some more stories.

MR: Okay, over and out.

NB: It goes by quick, right?